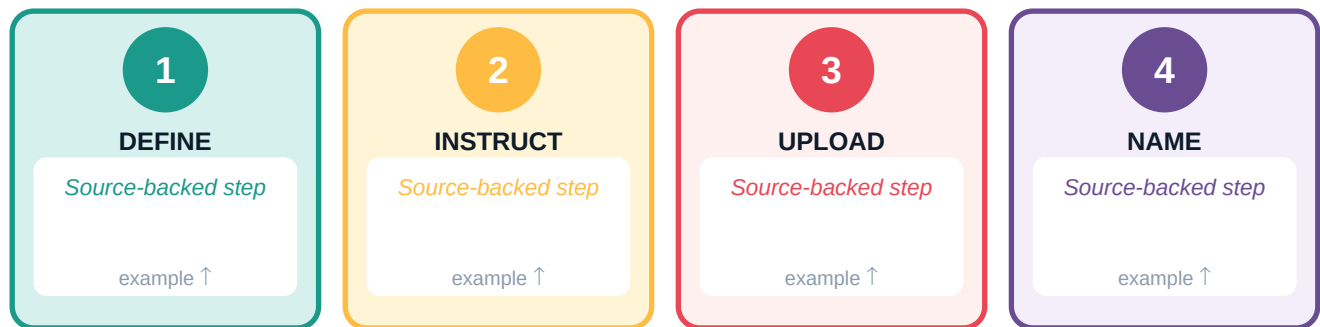


Projects and Persistent Instructions



SETTING UP PERSISTENT INSTRUCTIONS Persistent instructions are the highest-leverage single investment most regular AI users can make. Writing them well takes thirty minutes. The return on those thirty minutes compounds with every subsequent AI conversation.

WHAT TO INCLUDE IN PERSISTENT INSTRUCTIONS The most valuable things to specify in persistent instructions:

1. YOUR PROFESSIONAL CONTEXT Who you are, what you do, what organisation or sector you work in. This calibrates AI's assumptions about what background knowledge is relevant and what terminology is appropriate.

Example: "I am a senior solicitor at a UK mid-market law firm. My clients are typically owner-managed businesses. I communicate with clients, not other lawyers."

2. YOUR COMMUNICATION PREFERENCES Tone, vocabulary level, things you never want to see in output. This is where you codify the things you would otherwise correct in every first draft.

Example: "Write in plain English. No jargon unless I request it. No excessive hedging. No bullet lists unless I specify them. UK English throughout. Professional but accessible."

3. YOUR STANDARD AUDIENCE Who reads what you produce? This prevents AI from pitching responses at the wrong level.

Example: "Assume I am writing for a non-specialist reader unless I specify otherwise. Never assume technical knowledge of legal process or financial instruments."

- KEY CONSTRAINTS THAT ALWAYS APPLY

- Anything that, if AI ignored it, would make the output unusable.

- Legal constraints, brand constraints, regulatory constraints,
- relationship sensitivities.

Example: "I work in financial services. Do not make specific investment recommendations. Always include appropriate caveats where content could be interpreted as financial advice."

- THINGS YOU WANT AI TO ALWAYS DO
- Behaviours you want as default, not just when you remember to
- ask.

Example: "At the end of any factual output, flag any claims I should verify independently. If you are uncertain about any fact, say so explicitly rather than stating it with false confidence."

A TEMPLATE FOR PERSISTENT INSTRUCTIONS Here is a starting template. Adapt it to your situation:

About me: [Your role, sector, organisation type, years of experience if relevant]

What I typically need AI for: [Your most common use cases, writing, analysis, research, editing, planning]

My communication preferences: [Tone, vocabulary level, formatting preferences, things you never want]

My standard audience: [Who reads your output, clients, colleagues, the public, specialists, generalists]

Key constraints that always apply: [Legal, regulatory, brand, relationship, or accuracy constraints]

What I always want AI to do: [Default behaviours you want in every interaction, verification flags, format defaults, etc.]



PART III - BUILD AN AI ENVIRONMENT

TRY THIS SET UP YOUR PERSISTENT INSTRUCTIONS TODAY. USE THE TEMPLATE ABOVE. START WITH THE SECTIONS THAT P

After two weeks, review the instructions. What are you still correcting in every conversation? That's a gap in your persistent instructions. Add it.

SETTING UP A PROJECT Projects are more powerful than persistent instructions because they can also hold documents, ongoing outputs, and accumulated context. Here is how to approach setting one up:

STEP 1, DEFINE THE PROJECT'S PURPOSE What work is this project for? One client? One recurring task type? One ongoing work project? The answer determines what belongs in it.

STEP 2, WRITE THE PROJECT INSTRUCTIONS These are like persistent instructions but scoped to this project. Include the context specific to this work that doesn't belong in your general instructions.

STEP 3, UPLOAD RELEVANT DOCUMENTS What documents does AI need to do this project's work? Upload them. Brand guidelines, style guides, reference documents, previous outputs, client briefs.

STEP 4, NAME CONVERSATIONS CLEARLY Within the project, give conversations descriptive names. "Email sequence for Q4 campaign" is more useful six weeks later than "New Chat (3)."

Chapter 11 - Projects and Persistent Instructions

PRODUCT NOTE (VERIFIED SEPTEMBER 2026): ChatGPT Projects are available on free and paid plans, with file limits that vary by plan. Claude Projects are available on paid plans. Gemini offers workspaces and custom configurations, but the names, file behaviour, and availability vary by product and account. Feature details change frequently; verify current capabilities and limits in the platform's help centre before relying on a specific feature.

Volatility: HIGH

THE PROJECT FOR RECURRING WORK Some of the most valuable AI projects are not for unique work, but for recurring tasks. If you produce the same type of document weekly or monthly, a status report, a client briefing, a team update, a project containing your template, your style reference, and your standard content elements saves significant setup time.

For recurring work, the project contains:

A template for the document type
Style and tone specifications
An example of a completed version you were happy with
Any standard information that appears in every edition (team structure, project status, recurring context)

Each week or month, you open the project, paste in the new content or data, and ask AI to produce the new version to the same standard as the example.



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